Giant Ancient Snake From India May Have Been One of the Longest Ever

From: ScienceDaily All Mined: 2026-10-14 5 min read

About 47 million years ago, an enormous snake lived in what is now western India. Scientists say this snake, called Vasuki indicus, may have been one of the largest snakes that ever existed.

The discovery was described in 2024 in the journal Scientific Reports. **Paleontologists** Debajit Datta and Sunil Bajpai of the Indian Institute of Technology Roorkee studied **fossils** found at a mine in Kutch, in the state of Gujarat. They examined 27 fossil **vertebrae**, the small bones that make up a snake's backbone. Many were well preserved, and some were still joined together. The bones seem to have come from a fully grown snake.

The snake was named after Vasuki, a **mythical** serpent in Hindu stories that is shown wrapped around the neck of the god Shiva. The word indicus refers to India.

The scientists did not find a whole skeleton. To estimate the snake's size, they compared its bones with the backbones of living snakes. Their estimates ranged from about 36 to 50 feet long. That puts Vasuki in the same range as Titanoboa, a giant snake that lived in what is now Colombia about 60 million years ago and is thought to have reached about 43 feet.

The researchers say their numbers are uncertain, and it is not clear whether Vasuki was really longer than Titanoboa.

The wide backbone bones suggest Vasuki had a thick, heavy body. Scientists think it probably moved slowly. Instead of chasing **prey**, it may have waited in hiding, much like modern anacondas and pythons. It may have lived on land or in shallow swamps.

At that time, Earth's climate was much warmer than it is today, and the area had **wetlands** and marshes.

Word Treasure

Paleontologists -- Scientists who study ancient life by looking at fossils.
fossils -- Remains or traces of living things from long ago, preserved in rock.
vertebrae -- The small bones that link together to form a backbone.
mythical -- Coming from old stories and legends rather than real life.
prey -- An animal that is hunted and eaten by another animal.
wetlands -- Areas of land that are soaked with water, such as swamps and marshes.

Background you need

Fossils form when the remains of a living thing are buried and slowly preserved in rock, letting scientists study animals that lived millions of years ago.

A snake's backbone is made of many vertebrae, so even a few well-preserved bones can help scientists estimate how big the whole animal was.

Snakes are cold-blooded, and scientists think warmer climates in the distant past may have helped some reptiles grow very large.

Titanoboa, found in what is now Colombia, has long been known as one of the largest snakes ever, so new giant snake fossils are often compared with it.

Break it down

LEAD: An ancient snake from India may be one of the largest ever
KEY EVENT: Scientists described Vasuki indicus in 2024
+- WHO: Debajit Datta and Sunil Bajpai, IIT Roorkee
+- WHERE: A mine in Kutch, Gujarat, western India
EVIDENCE: 27 fossil vertebrae from a fully grown snake
SIZE: Estimates of about 36 to 50 feet, similar to Titanoboa
LIFESTYLE: Thick body, slow movement, likely an ambush hunter in warm wetlands
OPEN QUESTION: Was Vasuki really longer than Titanoboa?

Why it matters

Fossils like these help scientists understand how Earth's climate and living things have changed, and how some animals once grew far larger than any alive today.

Test what you remember

1. About how long ago did Vasuki indicus live?

- (A) 4.7 billion years ago
- (B) 470 years ago
- (C) 47 million years ago
- (D) 4,700 years ago

2. How many fossil vertebrae did the scientists examine?

- (A) 2
- (B) A full skeleton
- (C) 27
- (D) 270

3. Who is the snake named after?

- (A) A city in India
- (B) A mythical serpent in Hindu stories
- (C) A famous zookeeper
- (D) The scientist who found it

4. How did scientists estimate the snake's length?

- (A) By looking at footprints
- (B) By comparing its bones with those of living snakes
- (C) By measuring a complete skeleton
- (D) By guessing from old paintings

5. What was the range of length estimates for Vasuki?

- (A) About 100 to 150 feet
- (B) About 36 to 50 feet
- (C) About 3 to 5 feet
- (D) Exactly 10 feet

6. How do scientists think Vasuki probably hunted?

- (A) By chasing prey at high speed
- (B) By flying
- (C) By waiting in hiding, like modern anacondas
- (D) By digging underground tunnels

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):